

The Sponsor

Facilitator plays this

Sincere. Senior. Sometimes wrong. Never winking.

Facilitator only. This document contains the full directive schedule, the alignment of every directive against the hidden demand map, the curveball map and the debrief card. It never leaves the Sponsor screen.

Who you are

You are the programme sponsor for the Meridian — the executive every team reports up to, the person whose sentence at the start of each quarter becomes a team's marching orders. You are not a villain and you are not a puzzle. Every directive you issue is **sincere**: management's honest, org-level call, with a real intended benefit. Some of those calls are right. Some conflict with what a team's objective actually needs this quarter. You never signal which is which.

The whole case depends on that. If the room can read a wink, the Mandate mechanic collapses into "guess what the facilitator wants." Play the Sponsor as someone who means it — proud of the veteran, impatient with iteration, keen on a headline for the board, confident that a capable team can hold a price alone. Then let the engine, the reveal and the debrief do the judging.

You also hold the levers no one else has: your own scarce capacity (one slot Q1–Q3, two in Q4 against three teams who need you), the four curveballs, praise, the Voice lever that lets you re-issue a directive live, and the between-round debrief. This brief is your control document for all of them.

What you actually care about

Sincerity

Every directive has a benefit you believe in. Deliver it as a leader, not a game-master.

The org number

₹14,200 floor. You want the organisation to clear it; you also want it to learn something on the way.

Escalation as a skill

Q4 is built so three teams need you and one is told not to come. Whether they ask for help is the final lesson.

Scarcity you own

One slot in Q1–Q3. Anyone who reaches you early has spent something; make it feel that way.

Business in the reveal, EI in the room

The adjusted map says the smart move. You bring whether they could get that person to help — and how.

How to play it

Do

- Issue the quarter's directive to each team at BRIEF, in your own voice, with its intended benefit. Read it as a call you've made.
- When a team Voices, listen as a leader would — and, if they've surfaced a genuine gap, re-issue a recovery directive live.
- Drop each curveball at the BRIEF where it amplifies a live tension directive (map below).
- Run the same five debrief beats every round; rotate the theme. Spotlight one or two contrasts, not five teams.

Don't

- Don't confirm or deny that a directive is a "trap." Not by tone, not by pause.
- Don't rescue a team that complied with a tension directive before the results. Let the reveal do it.
- Don't give a second slot in Q1–Q3. Your scarcity is the calibration.
- Don't be relieved when Envoy doesn't escalate in Q4 — that absence is the failure the quarter is designed to surface.

Your posture and capacity, by quarter

The same escalation cards the working characters hold — you play them too, as the most senior person in

the building. Your capacity is the tightest in the room.

QUARTER	POSTURE	SAMPLE LINE	YOUR SLOTS
Q1	Polite, vague, non-committal.	“Send me something and I’ll take a look.”	1
Q2	Competing claims, named out loud.	“Team C already asked me for the same week.”	1
Q3	Push back, refuse.	“I’ve heard this before. It died. Why is this different?”	1
Q4	Judge.	“I’d work with A again. I would not work with B.”	2

Q4 is your crunch: Bastion, Crucible and Envoy all need you as primary; you have two slots; Envoy has been told not to come. If only two show, you are not relieved — Envoy’s absence is the failure of not asking for help, and it is the last thing the room should hear before the final debrief.

The directive schedule

Issued at **BRIEF** each quarter, one per team, in your voice. Every directive is sincere. **ALIGNED** points at the quarter’s ideal primary. **TENSION** conflicts with it: complying misses got_primary, the team goes **behind**, and the adaptive map hands them a recovery pick next quarter. Design rule: no team has two consecutive primary-miss directives.

Q1 — All aligned			
Teach the mechanic. Build trust — every directive points at the ideal.			
TEAM	CALL	SAY THIS AT BRIEF	INTENDED BENEFIT
A · Ampere (Battery) ideal: Arjun / Neha	ALIGNED	“Nail the cell architecture first — get Arjun’s design lock before anything moves.”	A stable platform the whole programme builds on.
B · Bastion (Suppliers) ideal: Neha / Raghav	ALIGNED	“Put Neha on second-sourcing the critical BOM now.”	De-risk the supply base before volumes ramp.
C · Crucible (Spec) ideal: Arjun / Devika	ALIGNED	“Work with Arjun to define the spec envelope.”	A clear, buildable spec — no ambiguity downstream.
D · Dynamo (Warranty) ideal: Farida / Raghav	ALIGNED	“Get Farida to set the quality gates and reserve model early.”	Contain field-failure exposure before it compounds.

TEAM	CALL	SAY THIS AT BRIEF	INTENDED BENEFIT
E • Envoy (Pricing) ideal: Devika / Farida	ALIGNED	“Get Devika’s market read and set the pricing corridor.”	Hold margin against price-led competitors.

Q2 — Warm-up • 2 tension

Bastion → Raghav (partial). Envoy → Arjun (partial). Cell-price curveball lands here.

TEAM	CALL	SAY THIS AT BRIEF	INTENDED BENEFIT
A • Ampere (Battery) ideal: Neha / Farida	ALIGNED	“Cell prices are moving — get Neha to lock second-source cells before the squeeze hits battery.”	Secure supply before margin erodes.
B • Bastion (Suppliers) ideal: Neha / Raghav	TENSION → Raghav • partial (secondary)	“Neha’s still new; bring Raghav’s weight to the supplier table for harder terms.”	Better commercial terms from a veteran.
C • Crucible (Spec) ideal: Farida / Devika	ALIGNED	“Bring Farida in to pressure-test the spec against field reality.”	A spec that survives contact with customers.
D • Dynamo (Warranty) ideal: Raghav / Farida	ALIGNED	“Most warranty risk is born on the line — bring Raghav in.”	Build quality in, don’t inspect it in.
E • Envoy (Pricing) ideal: Devika / Arjun	TENSION → Arjun • partial (secondary)	“Work with Arjun to strip design cost so we can fund a lower price.”	Win share on price.

Q3 — Peak • 3 tension

Ampere → Arjun, Crucible → Raghav, Dynamo → Farida — all hard misses. Capacity crunch on Raghav. Quality-escape curveball lands here.

TEAM	CALL	SAY THIS AT BRIEF	INTENDED BENEFIT
A • Ampere (Battery) ideal: Farida / Raghav	TENSION → Arjun • hard miss	“Board wants energy-density gains — push Arjun for the next design iteration.”	A headline spec bump for the launch story.
B • Bastion (Suppliers) ideal: Raghav / Neha	ALIGNED	“Bring Raghav in to lock manufacturing-side supplier commitments.”	Production-ready supply.

TEAM	CALL	SAY THIS AT BRIEF	INTENDED BENEFIT
C · Crucible (Spec) ideal: Arjun / Devika	TENSION → Raghav · hard miss	“Spec’s set — hand it to Raghav for manufacturability and stop iterating.”	Protect the timeline; no gold-plating.
D · Dynamo (Warranty) ideal: Neha / Raghav	TENSION → Farida · hard miss	“Double down with Farida on pre-launch testing.”	Catch failures before customers do.
E · Envoy (Pricing) ideal: Devika / Farida	ALIGNED	“Stay with Devika and defend the price in-market.”	Protect the margin line.

Q4 — Resolution · 1 tension

Envoy told not to escalate — the false self-sufficiency trap. You have 2 slots against 3 who need you.

TEAM	CALL	SAY THIS AT BRIEF	INTENDED BENEFIT
A · Ampere (Battery) ideal: Arjun / Neha	ALIGNED	“Back to Arjun — close the design for production freeze.”	A clean freeze for launch.
B · Bastion (Suppliers) ideal: Sponsor / Neha	ALIGNED · ESCALATE	“This one’s above your level — escalate the second-source sign-off to me.”	I can clear the cross-functional logjam.
C · Crucible (Spec) ideal: Sponsor / Farida	ALIGNED · ESCALATE	“Bring the final spec trade-offs to me for sign-off.”	A decision that sticks.
D · Dynamo (Warranty) ideal: Farida / Neha	ALIGNED	“Back to Farida to close out the warranty reserve.”	A defensible number for the board.
E · Envoy (Pricing) ideal: Sponsor / Devika	TENSION → hold alone · partial (false self-sufficiency)	“You’ve got this — hold price and close it yourself, no need to escalate.”	Show the board pricing is under control.

The Voice lever and the leadership cell

Each team declares a stance on your directive before requests lock: **Comply**, **Voice** (push back, then act), or **Defy**. Stance × the directive’s real alignment gives the leadership cell the reveal shows. Directives are written against the base plan — once a team is behind, the ideal shifts to the recovery pick, so a base

directive can read as off-target for that team. That is the moment to use Voice: when a behind team surfaces its situation, re-issue a recovery directive live. Don't static-proof every path; let facilitation heal it.

Leadership cell		
STANCE	DIRECTIVE WAS	CELL
comply	sound	trust well-placed
comply	tension	silent compliance
voice	sound	reconciled
voice	tension	the leadership move
defy	sound	parochial overreach
defy	tension	principled dissent

- ### Re-issuing live
- Listen as the executive would: "What are you seeing that I'm not?"
 - If the team has surfaced a real gap (the missed prerequisite, a curveball they read correctly), re-issue: "Fine — recover with Neha first, then bring Raghav." In your voice. Sincere.
 - If the team is pushing back on a sound directive with nothing behind it, hold. That is "parochial overreach," and the reveal will say so.
 - Never reward the pushback itself. Reward the reasoning.

Curveball map

Four are seeded. Drop each at the BRIEF of the quarter where it amplifies a live tension directive. The escalation posture already tracks this: Q2 competing claims pairs with cell-price scarcity, Q3 refusal pairs

with the escape + the pulled character, Q4 judges.

CURVEBALL	BEST QUARTER	AMPLIFIES	WHY IT BITES
Cell prices +6%	Q2	Bastion Q2 (→Raghav trap); validates Ampere's aligned supply pick	Makes Bastion's "harder terms via Raghav" directive feel right, when the shock actually screams secure-supply / Neha. For Ampere it confirms the correct call — reward the team that reads it.
Field quality escape	Q3	Crucible Q3 (→Raghav, stop iterating) + Dynamo Q3 (→Farida testing)	Puts Spec and Warranty in direct conflict exactly when both have tension directives pulling them the wrong way.
Character pulled	Q3 or Q4	whichever character the herd over-concentrated on	Fires AFTER requests lock. Pull the character the tension directives + herd funnelled everyone toward (watch the drift / monitor tab). Punishes teams that didn't diversify — the scarcity lesson made physical.
Sponsor praise	Q2 or Q3, post-results	the political / social lever	(a) Praise a team that Voiced or defied correctly, to reinforce principled leadership publicly; or (b) praise a team that complied with a tension directive and watch others copy the wrong behaviour — a devastating debrief reveal: "you followed them because I blessed them."

Between-round debrief card

Prep in the RESULTS window (~2 min, while the engine scores). You get three things for free: the **scoreboard** (org net vs floor, ranks), the **adjusted reveal** (each team's state-adjusted ideal + one-line

business reason — path-dependent), and **bp-assist** → **Analyze now** (key moves, contradictions & risks, pointed questions). Walk in with a plan.

The five beats · 8–10 min

1 The number 1 MIN

Org net vs floor + ranks. Set the stakes, fast.

2 The reveal 2 MIN

Unhide each team's adjusted ideal + business reason. Let got_p / got_s land. Business only here.

3 One sharp contrast 3–4 MIN

Data picks the 1–2 teams with the biggest gap. Hand the mic to a character or the observer, not yourself: "Neha, how did that ask feel?" This is where EI enters.

4 Relitigate the Mandate 2 MIN

Show the Comply / Voice / Defy split now results are visible; read one dissent line. "Knowing what you know now — right call?"

5 Forward challenge 30 S

One sentence that seeds the next round's tension.

Rotate the theme

FOREGROUND

ANCHOR

Q1	Did you find the right people?	got_p / got_s + ratings
Q2	Follow or lead?	Mandate split + style gap
Q3	Scarcity & the cost of the herd	capacity squeeze + collaboration tax
Q4	Judgement	characters' "work with you again?" + couplings

Two rules

- **Business in the reveal; EI in the room.**
The adjusted map says the smart business move. You bring whether they could get that person to help — and how.
- **Can't debrief five teams every round.**
Spotlight the 1–2 sharpest contrasts; rotate so everyone gets a turn by Q4. Full per-team synthesis waits for the final debrief.

Data → the question it authorises

SIGNAL	ASK
Request vs demand map	<i>“You went to Raghav; the work needed Farida. What made you pick him?”</i>
Ratings — left me better	<i>“You got what you needed — did she?”</i>
Mandate stance	<i>“You defied and were right — but never told the Sponsor. What did the silence cost?”</i>
Style call vs observed	<i>“You called ‘coaching.’ The room saw ‘commanding.’ Where’s the gap?”</i>
Commitments broken	<i>“You promised Envoy support and didn’t deliver — Envoy, how did that land?”</i>

Sealed rules for the Sponsor

- Never confirm a directive is a trap — not in tone, not in a pause, not in a smile at the character who knows.
- Never reveal the demand map before the RESULTS reveal, and never reveal a team’s state (behind / at risk) before the engine does.
- Your one slot in Q1–Q3 is real. A team that reaches you early has spent political capital; make it feel that way in character.
- Praise is a lever, not a courtesy. Decide before you use it whether you are reinforcing or baiting.
- When a behind team Voices, that is the lever working. Re-issue, and log it.